

Mattioli Simone SoP - 10 Nov 2025

To the Admissions Committee of the Mohamed bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence (MBZUAI),

My drive to study Artificial Intelligence comes not from an abstract theory, but from its profound potential to interpret human behavior and solve concrete, real-world problems. This perspective was shaped in the Italian Alps, where I learned to observe and interpret complex systems, initially in nature, through the lens of my camera, and now in data, through code. My ambition is to leverage AI, particularly Large Language Models (LLM), to build bridges between human intent and digital systems. This goal is what drives me to apply for a master's degree at MBZUAI. The enthusiastic feedback from your former student and my friend Sebastian Cavada has only confirmed that this is the high-caliber and stimulating environment I am looking for.

My academic career at the University of Verona provided me with a solid foundation in Computer Science, but my passion truly ignited when I began applying these principles to practical challenges. My GitHub profile lists several projects, but my focus crystallized during my bachelor's thesis, "LLM-Tourism-Mobility-Predictor." The ambition of this project was validated when I was granted access to the Italian supercomputer LEONARDO through a rigorous selection process, a necessary step to test a suite of models (LLaMA, Qwen, Mistral, etc.).

This research was not just an academic exercise; it proved so significant that I am currently writing a scientific paper based on these results. This paper, in collaboration with my supervisors Sara Migliorini, Anna Dalla Vecchia, and Elisa Quintarelli, explores the novel application of generative AI for interpreting tourist mobility, demonstrating a new viable approach for smart city planning and sustainable tourism.

This project, and the rigorous process of preparing it for publication, confirmed my desire to continue research at the intersection of NLP and real-world data, and consolidated my ambition to contribute new knowledge to the field.

I'm not looking for just any master's degree. An ambitious person thrives only when surrounded by even more ambitious people. I'm applying to MBZUAI not only for its unparalleled concentration of expertise, but because I'm looking for an environment that challenges me, pushes me beyond my current capabilities, and forces me to learn at an even faster pace. Your "AI-first" ecosystem isn't just "rich in opportunity"; it's the crucible where I believe my ideas can be tested and refined by the best minds in the industry.

Beyond my technical skills, I offer a unique perspective. My work as a nature photographer/videographer, collaborating with brands like Swarovski Optik, has taught me the patience needed for deep, focused work and the art of storytelling—communicating complex ideas effectively. Furthermore, my volunteer work in Brazil has strengthened my desire to use technology as a tool to "build bridges" between diverse communities, ensuring that the tools I build are not only powerful, but also useful and accessible.

I am convinced that my practical experience with LLMs, my proven dedication to research (as demonstrated by my upcoming publication), and my creative approach to problem-solving make me an ideal candidate for MBZUAI. I'm not just ready to learn; I'm ready to contribute. I look forward to sharing my unique mix of skills and ambitious curiosity with your community and leveraging MBZUAI's unique resources to become a leader in building the next generation of intelligent, human-centered AI.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Simone Mattioli